



Cover story Pakistan

pressure from Kiyani and his brass, Zardari's conciliatory and empathetic tone soon gave way to bellicosity as he spearheaded Pakistan's shrill campaign of outright denial for any responsibility for the Mumbai attacks, even dismissing arrested terrorist Ajmal Amir Kasab, as a "stateless individual". Zardari then categorically ruled out handing over terrorists on India's most wanted list and suspected to have taken shelter in Pakistan such as Dawood Ibrahim, the Mumbai don and Maulana Masood Azhar, the Jaish-e-Mohammad chief. Under pressure from the US, Pakistan did wilt and arrest the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) chief Zakiur Rahman Lakhvi apart from detaining Azhar. But Pakistani leaders reiterated that those arrested would be tried under their law and not be extradited to India. For New Delhi, it was a familiar ploy that would see them being freed after a few months for lack of evidence.

The big message for India: The army is back in control in Pakistan. The fledgling democratic government had become inconsequential in its response to the unfolding crisis. From now on it was Kiyani not Zardari who would have the final say on the future direction that Pakistan would take. A senior Indian official termed it dramatically as, "declaration of the Pakistan Army of its independence." There is now nothing stopping Kiyani from directly taking charge of governance in Pakistan. But unlike Pervez Musharraf, his predecessor, he has shown no inclination of staging a bloodless coup or taking over as President. Not yet. For the moment he remains content of letting the world know who the real boss of Pakistan is.

Long time Pakistan Army watcher Michael Krepon of the Washington DC-based Stimson Center believes "there never really has been a fundamental shift in power in Pakistan" despite the democratic elections in March, 2008. The army, which is the most organised institution in Pakistan, has always been in control of its affairs especially on national security. Krepon doesn't believe that Kiyani has staged a coup through the backdoor. Instead he argues that Kiyani is only engaged in "balancing pressing external demands with internal security dilemmas."

For India though, the emergence of Kiyani as the real centre of power has serious implications. Given the meticulous way the Mumbai attacks were planned and then executed, it was clear to Indian investigators that this was a commando-type operation that possibly had



MARGINALISED Zardari's credibility

the involvement of a state actor. With Kasab singing about his LeT and ISI handlers and physical evidence mounting in terms of satellite phone calls, equipment and boats used for the attack, Pakistan's hand seemed to be smeared all over it. Even Rice told Zardari firmly that the US had evidence to show the links. India, like much of the world, is willing to believe that Zardari and his civilian establishment were probably not involved in sanctioning such a heinous act. But with ISI's hand or at least that of its "alumnus" in the form of retired officers being seen, the analysis is that the army may be deeply involved in the plot.

The reason the army and therefore, Kiyani, has emerged as the prime suspect is that it stands to gain most from the outcome of the

ZARDARI, GILANI AND SHARIF COMING OUT FROM THE ALL PARTY MEETING